

“Space or Schema?”
Rhythm, Meter, and Pitch in C. P. E. Bach’s Symphony in D Major, Wq. 183/1”
(Reader’s report)

I like the spirit of this submission, which reflects the author’s intention “to provide a deep analytical dive into a single piece rather than to make a sweeping theoretical claim” (p. 1), and I sympathize with the suggestion to treat the analyses as an “implicit theoretical statement about equivalence between tonal and metric manipulations” (p. 2). I find the analyses of such manipulations for the most part thorough and illuminating. Still, I have qualms about the methodological horizon within which this enterprise is situated. The concept of “manipulations” implies that the compositional strategies observed in C. P. E. Bach’s Symphony in D major, Wq. 183/1, were addressed toward his audience and intended to achieve a specific effect on it. This clashes with the author’s goal “to present a present-day analytical hearing of the piece rather than to engage in historically informed listening” (p. 2). Furthermore, I have misgivings about the execution. While analyses of some passages are detailed and lengthy, others are quick and brief. The author returns to the same passages several times, moves back and forth between different passages and touches upon certain issues without fully exposing them. Those changes of pace and direction as well as the cross-references between tonal and metric manipulations are disorienting and they don’t help the reader to follow the argument. Last but not least, I take issues with some details.

Schemata

The I-vi-IV opening of Example 2 is described by the author as a “galant Romanesca” (p. 3) but the bass line of the galant Romanesca consists of scale degrees 1-7-6-3 (Gjerdingen 2007: 33) and it features a melody consisting of scale degrees 1-5-1-1 (Gjerdingen 2007: 39), neither of which can be found in Example 2. The author contends that this Romanesca “is the home key of G major” (p. 3), although the home key is D major. Further issues with identification of schemata occur in Example 14, where the author finds the Prinner in mm. 37-40 and Fonte in mm. 39-40, although the entire passage represents a chain of bass suspensions (Sanguinetti 2012: 135). When the author writes that “a fully diminished seventh chord followed by a 6/4 sonority a half step above in the bass provide unambiguous tonal position finding” (p. 4), they would be well advised to refer to Vasili Byros’s chapter “Of Elegant Tones and Fantastical Progressions: A Historical, Schema-Based, and Comprovisational Perspective on Diminished Seventh-Chord Modulation, c. 1720–1830. Or, an Exercise in *corporis studium*” in *The Oxford Handbook of Music and Corpus Studies* (ed. Daniel Shanahan et al.). While the volume is still forthcoming, the chapter is available online. The relation of schemata to form, to which the author turns near the end (p. 26), is tentative and the fleeting references to Byros’s and Caplin’s work don’t suffice to make sense of the author’s discussion of the formal function of the Passo Indietro in mm. 27-28.

Sonata form

The shift “to large-scale formal strategies” (p. 35) comes out of the blue and framing it in terms of Hepokoski and Darcy’s Sonata Theory is problematic because the norms on which this theory rests were not yet established in the mid-1770s. This was recently pointed out by Burstein (2020) and Greenberg (2022), who came up with alternative approaches to the study of sonata form in this period. The author doesn’t mention Burstein and his reference to Greenberg remains

inconsequential. The lack of historical perspective upon the sonata form is in evidence from the outset. When the author points to the “I: HC MC in Hepokoski and Darcy’s (2006) terms” (p. 5) at m. 34 of C. P. E. Bach’s symphony, it is far from clear if this HC is really an MC or, rather, the first of two caesuras following *Quintabsätze* in the main and the dominant key, respectively, and thus resulting in what Burstein (2020: 182-200) calls an “exposition with two half-cadential breaks.”

Meter

In the author’s words, “Bach creates a meter finding problem that surprisingly resonates with nascent metric theories from his milieu around the time of composition (Kirnberger and Schulz 1774, Mirka 2009)” (p. 1) but this is not so surprising. After all, Kirnberger was J. S. Bach’s student and belonged to the Berlin circle of music theorists, in which C. P. E. Bach was glorified. His compositions are cited by Kirnberger and the author mentions one such citation in footnote 8. Thus, rather than treating it as a curiosity, it would have been more appropriate to explore the connection in greater detail. Furthermore, it would have been appropriate to reach for eighteenth-century vocabulary in describing C. P. E. Bach’s metric manipulations. The one shown in Example 6b is not a “pre-cadential hemiola” (p. 10), as the author calls it, but an *imbroglio* (Mirka 2009: 135-150) created by parallelism, which is typical of this manipulation. (The author mentions “registral extremes” in creating this effect, but they are by-products of parallelism, and this important preference factor of metric perception [MPR 1] plays a role in many other examples without being acknowledged by the author.) What the author calls “metric states” in Example 12 or, rather, a table “summarizing the interactions of meter, tonality, harmonic/contrapuntal schemata, and metric states,” are the lowest levels of metrical hierarchy and thus don’t deserve the term “metric states,” which typically refers to correlation of several levels (Cohn 2001).

To sum up, what I’m missing in this submission is a clear line of argument that would bring together all the analytical insights scattered here and there throughout its course and present a sustained analysis of an entire movement of C. P. E. Bach’s symphony or its substantial chunk. In order to find this line of argument, the author will have to engage in deep reconceptualization of their enterprise and redress some of its details. This won’t be an easy task and it isn’t clear if the author will be able to accomplish it. I recommend to revise and resubmit in hope that they will!

References:

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- Cohn, Richard. 2001. Complex Hemiolas, Ski-Hill Graphs and Metric Spaces. *Music Analysis* 20/3: 295–326.
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- Greenberg, Yoel. 2022. *How Sonata Forms: A Bottom-Up Approach to Musical Form*. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Mirka, Danuta. 2009. *Metric Manipulations in Haydn and Mozart: Chamber Music for Strings, 1787–1791*. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Sanguinetti, Giorgio. 2012. *The Art of Partimento: History, Theory, and Practice*. New York: Oxford University Press.